CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

OPERATIONS MANAGER IN THE AI ERA

Every business has a person who actually makes the machine run. That's this job.

★ TL;DR — ~$75K median at this rung, reached over 2–4 years of running real operations. The catch: you inherit every broken process and every staffing headache, and 'operations' means whatever nobody else owns. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

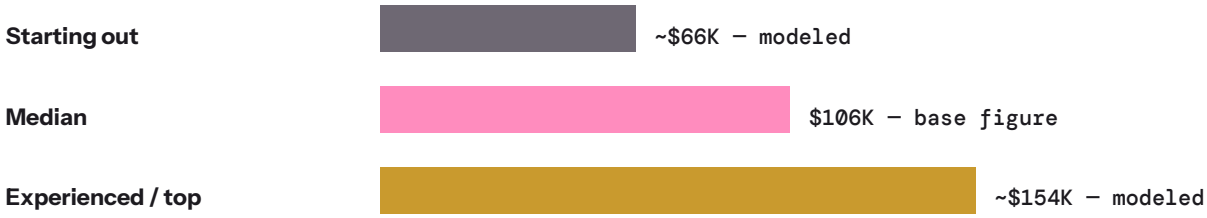
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$106K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK MEDIUM · STATE LICENSE

- Ops managers are the connective tissue between strategy and the daily grind.
- The skill compounds: every process you fix teaches you the whole business.
- AI optimizes schedules and reports; deciding what should exist at all stays human.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Operations Manager is a ~$106K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A OPERATIONS MANAGER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Oversee daily operations: staffing, schedules, output, quality
- ✓ Fix broken processes and document how things should run
- ✓ Manage budgets, vendors, and supplies

✓ Hire, train, and coach frontline teams

Think: the stage manager of a theater that never closes — the show runs nightly, and every missing prop is your emergency.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI forecasts demand, builds schedules, drafts reports, and flags bottlenecks from data. The clipboard layer of operations is automating quickly.	A machine breaks, a key employee quits, a customer explodes — live judgment with incomplete information is the core of the job.

⚠ **The 2–4 year ramp is real: ops managers are promoted from people who've survived the floor, not hired off courses. Your hours bend around the business's worst days.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ No two days alike; boredom is rare ✓ You learn an entire business, not a slice ✓ A proven path toward general management	✗ Problems escalate to you by definition ✗ Evenings and weekends, when the operation runs them ✗ Invisible when things go well, blamed when they don't

Good fit? You're a natural fixer who stays level when three things break at once.
Bad fit? You want a tidy desk job with predictable days and no people management.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — SUPERVISOR LADDER	DOOR B — SMALL BUSINESS OPS
Climb from team lead to supervisor to operations manager inside one business. You earn credibility on the floor and learn the operation piece by piece.	Join a small company as its operations hire — part manager, part firefighter. Scope is huge from day one; you'll learn fast and wear every hat.

Smart move: Document every process you fix with before/after numbers — ops promotions go to people who can show a machine running better because of them.
Where you land after: General manager, director of operations, or COO-track roles in smaller companies.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET ON	OWN A	LEARN THE	MEET CREDENTIAL	FIX A	RUN THE

STEP 1 — Get on the floor

PAID · YEAR 1

- Take a frontline or team-lead role in an operation you respect.
- Learn the work your future teams will do — credibility starts here.

STEP 2 — Own a shift or a team

YEARS 1-2

- Run schedules, handle call-outs, solve the daily breakage.
- Start writing down how things should work — your first SOPs.

STEP 3 — Learn the money side

YEARS 1-3

- Read your operation's budget until you can explain every line.
- Track one cost and bring it down measurably.

STEP 4 — Meet credential and licensing steps

FEES VARY · YEARS 2-3

- Complete the management credentials your industry values.
- Where your operation is state-regulated — food, transport, facilities — complete the state licensing requirements for managers in that track.

STEP 5 — Fix a whole process

YEARS 2-3

- Take one broken workflow end to end: measure, redesign, train, verify.
- Present the result in money and time saved.

STEP 6 — Run the operation

WORKING · YEARS 3-4

- Step into the ops manager seat — yours or a smaller company's.
- Own staffing, budget, and output as one system.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: list operations near you hiring team leads — that's the real entry point.
- □ Days 1–30: in a frontline or lead role, learning the operation from inside.
- □ Days 31–60: first documented process fix; budget basics study started.
- □ Days 61–90: running shifts or a small team with visible reliability.

□ Day 90: you're in the pipeline — floor credibility building, first fixes on record.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **MAKE THE MACHINE RUN.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.